

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Food

Store Simple Food. Use It Wisely.

In an emergency, food does not need to be perfect. It needs to nourish people, store well, be simple to prepare, conserve fuel and water, and last long enough to matter.

SIMPLE FOOD IS GOOD FOOD.

IMMEDIATE ACTION

If you need food right now

1

Use food that will spoil first.

Eat safely refrigerated and fresh foods before opening long-term storage.

2

Protect the food you have.

Keep it dry, covered, away from pests and chemicals, and away from contaminated water.

3

Cook simply.

Do not waste fuel trying to make elaborate meals.

4

Make sure everyone gets enough.

In a real shortage, fair distribution matters.

BEGIN WITH FAMILIAR FOODS

What should you store?

Start with foods that are familiar, nutritious, long-lasting, easy to prepare, and easy to rotate into normal meals.

- Rice
- Beans and lentils
- Oats
- Pasta and flour
- Salt and cooking oil
- Canned foods
- Dried fruit
- Nuts and seeds
- Shelf-stable milk or alternatives
- Simple seasonings

Store what you already know how to eat. Do not build an emergency supply around foods no one likes or knows how to prepare.

A USEFUL FOUNDATION

Rice and beans

Rice and beans are inexpensive, easy to store, familiar, filling, and nutritious. A small amount can feed many people when combined with other basic foods.

Dry beans can require a lot of cooking fuel. Lentils and smaller beans usually cook faster. When fuel is limited, foods that cook quickly become more valuable.

FOOD AND COOKING ARE CONNECTED

Think about fuel

How much fuel will this food require?

A balanced supply gives you options:

USE NO FUEL

No-cook

Nut butters, crackers, nuts, dried fruit, and ready-to-eat canned foods.

USE LESS FUEL

Quick-cook

Lentils, oats, pasta, couscous, and quick-cooking grains.

PLAN AHEAD

Long-cook

Dry beans and whole grains.

CONSERVE DRINKING WATER

Think about water

Some foods need large amounts of water to prepare. During a shortage, that can become a problem.

- Cook with only the water you need.
- Use cooking liquid in the meal instead of discarding it.
- Avoid foods that require repeated rinsing when water is scarce.

Food should not consume the water you need for drinking.

ENERGY AND SATISFACTION

Fat, salt, and flavor matter

Include useful fats

Fats provide concentrated energy and make simple foods more satisfying. Cooking oil, nut butters, nuts, and seeds are useful sources. Rotate oils regularly because they do not store as long as dry grains and beans.

Keep simple seasonings

Salt is useful for flavor, cooking, and some food-preservation methods. Pepper, dried herbs, spices, bouillon, or seasoning mixes can make repetitive meals much easier to eat.

READY TO EAT

Canned food

Canned food is already cooked, needs little or no additional fuel, has a long shelf life, and is easy to portion. Keep a manual can opener.

DISCARD CANS THAT ARE

- Bulging or leaking.
- Badly rusted.
- Punctured or cracked.
- Severely crushed or dented.

When in doubt, discard questionable food.

DURING A POWER OUTAGE

Refrigerated food

- Keep refrigerator and freezer doors closed as much as possible.
- An unopened refrigerator generally keeps food cold for about four hours.
- Use time and measured temperature to judge safety, not smell or appearance alone.
- Never taste food to determine whether it is safe.

When in doubt, throw it out.

BUILD GRADUALLY

How much food should you keep?

Plan in **person-days**. One person supplied for one day equals one person-day. Multiply the number of people by the number of days you want to cover.



Calculate your household

People × Days = **Person-days**

1 person for 3 days	3 person-days
2 people for 7 days	14 person-days
4 people for 14 days	56 person-days

Build one complete day first

Set aside one full day of realistic food for each person. Include breakfast, two simple main meals, a no-cook option, snacks, cooking fat, and seasonings. Check how much water and fuel that day requires. Then multiply that complete day to reach your household target.

MORNING

Oats, shelf-stable milk, dried fruit, or another familiar breakfast.

MAIN MEALS

Rice, lentils, pasta, canned foods, or other simple combinations.

NO-COOK BACKUP

Nut butter, crackers, nuts, dried fruit, or ready-to-eat cans.

DO NOT FORGET

Oil, salt, seasonings, safe water, fuel, and special dietary foods.

Easy shopping method

Each time you shop, buy one or two extra shelf-stable foods that your household already uses. Write the date on them, place them behind older supplies, and keep building until every person-day is covered.

PREVENT WASTE

Rotate your food

First in

FIRST OUT

Use the oldest food first, then replace what you use. Emergency food should not sit forgotten for years.

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple food kit

☐ Rice

☐ Lentils or beans

☐ Oats or other grains

☐ Canned foods

☐ Nut butter

☐ Nuts and seeds

☐ Dried fruit

☐ Cooking oil

☐ Salt and seasonings

☐ Manual can opener

☐ Cooking pot and utensils

☐ Safe cooking method

☐ Food-storage containers

☐ Labels and marker

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Store foods no one will eat.

✗ Depend only on foods that require long cooking.

✗ Forget the water and fuel cooking requires.

✗ Store large amounts without rotating them.

✗ Open refrigerated food repeatedly during an outage.

✗ Eat questionable food to avoid waste.

✗ Forget special dietary or medical needs.

✗ Assume calories are the only thing that matters.

PLAN FOR REAL NEEDS

Special needs

Some people may need infant formula, soft foods, low-sodium foods, diabetic-friendly foods, allergy-safe foods, or foods that are easy to chew or digest. Pets also need food.

Emergency planning should include the people and animals who actually live with you.

TRY THIS NOW

Food practice

Choose one day. Pretend there is no electricity and you cannot go to the store. Prepare every meal using only food you have, your emergency cooking method, and limited water.

1. Did I have enough food, and was it satisfying?
2. Did it require too much cooking fuel?
3. Did I use too much water?
4. Was anything missing?
5. Could I eat this way for a week?

This is one of the easiest ways to discover weaknesses in your food plan.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I have several days of familiar food.

☐ I have no-cook and quick-cooking foods.

☐ I have a safe way to cook without normal utilities.

☐ I have enough cooking fuel and a manual can opener.

☐ I have salt, oil, and simple seasonings.

☐ I rotate my stored food.

☐ I have considered special dietary needs.

☐ I know how much water my stored foods require.

REMEMBER

Emergency food does not need to be fancy.

Simple food that can be stored, cooked, and shared is valuable.

A handful of rice and beans in a real shortage can be worth more than gold.

STORE SIMPLE. COOK SIMPLE. WASTE NOTHING.

Official guidance

Use current food-safety instructions during an outage, flood, or other emergency.

FDA: Food and Water Safety During Power Outages and Floods (<https://www.fda.gov/food/buy-store-serve-safe-food/food-and-water-safety-during-power-outages-and-floods>)

USDA: Food Safety During Temporary Power Outages (<https://www.usda.gov/about-usda/news/blog/avoid-foodborne-illness-during-temporary-power-outages>)

American Red Cross: Survival Kit Supplies(<https://www.redcross.org/get-help/how-to-prepare-for-emergencies/survival-kit-supplies.html>)
